are with them. Now we have to ensure our daughter wins from her maternal home." The reference is to Mebooba's elder daughter, Iltija Mufti, 33, who is making her assembly poll debut.

Iltija is the candidate from the Bijbehara-Srigufwara constituency, where Mehbooba made her debut in 1996. The seat has been with the PDP since 1999, with senior leader Abdul Rehman Veeri holding the fort. Like elsewhere in Kashmir, delimitation has altered its boundaries and a good number of PDP faithful now find themselves in other constituencies. But a good quantum of the 100,000-plus eligible voters are expected at the booths on September 18 in the first phase.



ABID BHAT

WE THE PEOPLE PDP candidate Iltija Mufti at a roadshow in Bijbehara, Sept. 7

Raised in her grandfather's house in Srinagar by her mother, Iltija came into her own after the abrogation of Article 370 in August 2019, becoming the face of PDP's protest during Mehbooba's long detention under the Public Safety Act. An articulate leader (she has a master's in international relations from Warwick University in the UK), Iltija has segued well into her role. A natural connect is evident during her door-to-door campaign, and it's mutual. A milling, cheering crowd always gathers—men, women, young, old, they all cheer for her, offer garlands and candy, and kiss her head, a sign of regard in the local culture.

"The Centre is trying to grab our jobs, land and resources," says Iltija to an audience in the tiny Dupatyaar village even as slogans like, '*Na jhukne wale PDP, na bikne wale PDP* (The PDP won't bow, it won't sell out)' rend the air. "This election is to save our future and identity, do not miss this chance. *Sherni ka baccha sher hota hai*. I'll fight like a lion in the assembly for you."

The PDP faces challenges across the Valley, but the biggest fight is in its old backyard. Iltija is up against Bashir Ahmad Veeri, the National Conference (NC) candidate. He lost the previous two elections from here but over the last decade has made inroads into the PDP's turf, exploiting the schisms from its unpopular alliance with the BJP in 2015. The saffron party has fielded an old hand here, Sofi Yousuf.

Some had suggested that Iltija be fielded from Anantnag East or Pahalgam, but her mother decided their home turf was best, shifting the old warhorse Abdul Rehman Veeri to Anantnag East (it has alienated his core supporters). Bijbehara was among the five assembly segments where the PDP had a thin lead in the general election and is considered a 'safe seat'. A PDP leader says Mehbooba's insecurities have grown since the party's post-2018 implosion. Now, ahead of the election, another set of leaders have quit over ticket allocation. "We were denied because Mehbooba does not want to see a parallel leadership to her daughter in the party," says a young leader who quit recently.

The PDP is at its weakest, but Iltija is not worrying about that now. She has already covered all 87 villages and 17 wards in her seat, and brims with purpose—she feels her voice can add weight to public issues even in an assembly with truncated powers. "The next CM is going to be like the mayor of a municipality. What will matter is how strongly you raise your voice on issues," she says. As Iltija leaves for another meeting, three elderly men walking by the shrine declare they will be supporting her as she is the Mufti's granddaughter. "Those who earned benefits and jobs have abandoned the Muftis here," says a bearded man in his 70s. "I am not among them. I got a job long before they came to power." ■

A NEW CHALLENGE

- **Iltija Mufti, a strong voice of protest for the PDP during mother Mehbooba's detention, is making her poll debut**
- **The PDP is at its weakest now, riven by dissent. Mehbooba is not contesting**